



A LAYERSYNC FIELD GUIDE

The Layer Map

What using AI actually looks like at each stage of a business, how to tell which stage you are on, and exactly what has to change to reach the next one.

- 1 Asking** a person, a chat window, and a copy button
- 2 Assisting** AI moves into the tools where the work lives
- 3 Automating** work happens without a person starting it
- 4 Delegating** you hand over outcomes instead of steps
- 5 Compounding** the systems become the operating model

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How to use this guide

This is not a guide about AI tools. It is a guide about where the work in your business actually happens, and how much of it still depends on a person remembering to do something.

Most businesses we speak to describe themselves as "using AI." When we look closely, what that usually means is that two or three people have a chat window open and paste things in and out of it. That is a real starting point. It is also the layer where almost no value compounds, because everything gained is gained once and then lost when the tab closes.

There are five layers. They are not levels of sophistication for their own sake. They describe how much leverage you get from every hour of human attention you put into the business. Each layer has a real ceiling, and each ceiling has a specific cause.

WHAT YOU WILL WALK AWAY WITH

- An honest read of which layer you are on today, scored by you, not sold to you.
- A clear picture of why almost every business stalls in the same place, and what actually causes it.
- The four jumps, with what has to be true before each one is even possible.
- Five working prompts that produce real documents you can use, not tips.
- A one page map of your own systems that you can fill in today.

HOW TO WORK THROUGH IT

Do the diagnostic on the next page before you read anything else. It takes about four minutes and it is more useful when you have not yet read the descriptions, because you will answer honestly instead of aspirationally. Then read the layer you landed on, and the one above it. Then go to the jump that connects them.

ONE RULE BEFORE YOU START

You cannot skip a layer. Every business that has tried to buy its way from Layer 2 to Layer 4 has ended up with an expensive system nobody trusts, because the groundwork underneath it was never laid. If that sounds like a sales line, read Part Three. It is the most important section in this document and it is the reason most projects fail.

PART ONE · LOCATE YOURSELF

The four minute diagnostic

Tick every statement that is **true of your business today**, not true of your plans. Work through the blocks in order. Be strict. A statement that is true for one person on one good week is not true of your business.

BLOCK A THE GATE TO LAYER 2

- ☐ More than one person uses AI in their normal work at least weekly, without being reminded.
- ☐ AI is available inside at least one tool we already work in, not only in a separate chat window.
- ☐ We have written down at least one instruction or prompt that more than one person reuses.

BLOCK B THE GATE TO LAYER 3

- ☐ At least one process runs from start to finish without a person triggering each step.
- ☐ When a form, message, or enquiry comes in, something useful happens before a human opens it.
- ☐ If one of those automations stopped working, we would know within a day.

BLOCK C THE GATE TO LAYER 4

- ☐ Our main tools share information automatically. Nobody is copying data between them by hand.
- ☐ There is one place where a customer's full history can be seen without asking a colleague.
- ☐ At least one system handles unexpected cases on its own and escalates to a person only when it genuinely needs to.

BLOCK D THE GATE TO LAYER 5

- ☐ Each system has a named owner and a regular review of how it is performing.
- ☐ We can take on more work of a common type without adding headcount.
- ☐ If the founder or manager were unreachable for two weeks, core operations would continue without degrading.

SCORING

Start at Block A. A block is **passed** if you ticked at least two of its three statements. Count how many blocks you passed in **unbroken sequence** from A onwards. Stop counting at the first block you did not pass. Your layer is that number plus one.

0 blocks passed Layer 1	1 A only Layer 2	2 A and B Layer 3	3 A, B and C Layer 4	4 all four Layer 5
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If you passed a later block but failed an earlier one, you have bought a capability you cannot yet support. This is common and it is worth taking seriously. It usually means a tool was purchased to solve a problem that was really a process problem or a data problem. Read Part Three.

PART ONE · LOCATE YOURSELF

The five layers at a glance

Each layer is defined by one question: when the work happens, who or what is doing it, and what happens when something unexpected shows up.

LAYER	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHO DOES THE WORK	THE CEILING YOU HIT
1 Asking	A chat window in a browser tab. Ask, copy, paste.	A person, one task at a time.	Nothing you did today makes tomorrow easier. Value dies with the tab.
2 Assisting	AI inside the tools you already use. Drafting, summarising, searching.	A person, moving faster.	You still touch every step. Output scales with hours worked.
3 Automating	Trigger and action. Form comes in, email goes out, record is created.	A rule you wrote, until it meets something you did not predict.	Anything unusual falls back on a human, silently. Brittle at the edges.
4 Delegating	Systems that own an outcome, not a step. They decide, act, and escalate.	The system, with a person reviewing.	Requires connected data and real ownership. Most businesses never get here.
5 Compounding	The business runs on its systems. People do judgment and relationships.	The organisation itself.	The constraint becomes strategy and demand, not capacity.

AN HONEST NOTE ABOUT DIRECTION

Higher is not automatically better. The layers measure leverage per hour of human attention, and leverage only matters where volume, repetition, or risk exist. A six person consultancy doing bespoke, high touch work may be perfectly and permanently right at Layer 2. A business processing four hundred enquiries a month is losing money every day it stays there. Before you decide to climb, be clear about which one you are.

Anyone selling you Layer 5 without asking about your volumes, your data, and who currently owns your processes is selling you software, not an outcome.

02

The layers in detail

One page each. Read the layer you scored, then read the one above it. The goal is recognition, not aspiration. If a page feels uncomfortably accurate, that is the page you are on.

1 Asking

A person, a chat window, and a copy button.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE DAY TO DAY

Someone has a chat tool open in a browser tab. They paste in a client email and ask for a reply. They ask it to tidy a proposal, summarise a long document, or come up with names for something. It works. The output is good enough. They paste it back into the real tool where the work lives, and move on.

Usage is personal and uneven. The two people who like it use it constantly. Everyone else forgets it exists. There is no shared standard, so the same task done by two people produces two different qualities of result.

WHAT IT QUIETLY COSTS YOU

Every good prompt someone writes is thrown away at the end of the day. The person who found the perfect way to draft your quote follow ups is the only one who knows it, and when they are on leave, that capability is on leave too. You are paying the full cost of a capability while capturing almost none of its value.

There is a second, less obvious cost. Because the tool has no access to your actual data, every answer is generic. So people spend their time explaining context in order to get an answer, which is often nearly as long as just doing the task.

YOU ARE ON LAYER 1 IF

Your AI usage would disappear entirely if two specific people left, and nobody could tell you what your business uses AI for without asking around.

THE CEILING

Nothing compounds. Layer 1 makes individuals slightly faster and makes the business no more capable. That is not a failure. It is simply the natural limit of a tool that has no memory of your business and no place to put its output.

Worth saying plainly: Layer 1 is where you should start. The mistake is not being here. The mistake is being here for two years and calling it an AI strategy.

2 Assisting

AI moves into the tools where the work already lives.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE DAY TO DAY

The chat window stops being a separate destination. AI now sits inside your inbox, your documents, your notes, your customer records, your code editor. It drafts the reply where the reply is written. It summarises the call inside the tool that recorded the call.

Something else changes here, and it matters more than the tools do. Prompts start getting written down and shared. A standard emerges for how your business writes a proposal, answers a complaint, or briefs a supplier. That shared standard is the real asset of Layer 2, not the software.

WHAT IT QUIETLY COSTS YOU

Speed feels like progress, and for a while it is. But look carefully at any task and you will notice the shape has not changed: a person decides to start, the person supplies the context, the person reviews, the person moves the result to wherever it goes next. You have made the human faster at every step, and left the human in every step.

This is why Layer 2 businesses often report that AI saved them time but their team is no less busy. The saved minutes get absorbed. Capacity is still bought in hours.

YOU ARE ON LAYER 2 IF

Your team is measurably faster, you have some shared prompts or templates, and nothing whatsoever happens in your business when everyone goes home.

THE CEILING

Output still scales with hours worked. You have improved the rate, not the model. Doubling throughput still means roughly doubling the people, and the quality of any given task still depends on which person picked it up.

Layer 2 gives you a better keyboard. It does not give you a second pair of hands.

3 Automating

Work starts happening without a person starting it.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE DAY TO DAY

Something finally runs on its own. A form submission creates a record and sends a confirmation. A signed document triggers an invoice. A new enquiry is tagged, routed, and answered with a first response before anyone has opened it. Reports build themselves on a Monday morning.

This is a genuine and significant jump. For the first time, work happens while the office is empty. Most businesses that reach here feel, correctly, that they have crossed a line.

WHAT IT QUIETLY COSTS YOU

Automations are rules, and rules only cover what you thought of when you wrote them. The moment reality produces something unexpected, a duplicate record, a client who replies to the wrong thread, a field left blank, a supplier who changes a format, the rule either fails loudly or, far worse, succeeds incorrectly and quietly.

So a shadow job appears. Somebody, usually the most capable person you have, becomes the human backup for the automations. They check that things ran. They fix the ones that did not. They are the exception handler, and it is nobody's official role, which means it is invisible on every org chart and in every budget.

YOU ARE ON LAYER 3 IF

You have automations you rely on, and you also have at least one person who quietly checks whether they worked.

THE CEILING

Every new edge case is a new rule someone has to build and maintain. Complexity grows faster than coverage. Eventually the automations become a thicket that only one person understands, and changing anything feels risky, so nobody does.

WHY THIS IS WHERE NEARLY EVERYONE STOPS

Layer 3 is the most commonly sold version of "AI transformation," because it can be delivered quickly and demonstrated in a meeting. It is also where the returns flatten hardest. Part Three explains the real reason businesses cannot get past it, and it is almost never the automations themselves.

4 Delegating

You hand over outcomes instead of building steps.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE DAY TO DAY

You stop describing how a job should be done and start describing what a finished job looks like. The system reads the enquiry, checks availability against the real calendar, looks up the customer's history, answers the question, books the slot, updates the record, notifies the right person, and follows up in four days if nothing happened.

When something unusual arrives, it does not break. It recognises that it is outside its confidence, takes the safe action, and escalates to a named human with the context already assembled. Nobody has to go looking for what happened.

WHAT IT REQUIRES, AND THIS IS THE WHOLE GAME

- **Connected data.** The system can read and write across your tools through their interfaces, so it is reasoning about your real business, not a copy of it.
- **A defined outcome.** Someone has written down what "done and correct" means, including what must never happen.
- **An escalation path.** A real person owns the exceptions, and receives them with context, not just an alert.
- **A record of its own work.** Every decision is logged, so the system can be audited and improved rather than trusted blindly.

WHAT CHANGES FOR YOU

Your role shifts from operating to reviewing. You are no longer asking whether the work got done. You are asking whether the system is making good decisions, and where its judgment needs sharpening. Capacity stops being tied to headcount for that category of work.

YOU ARE ON LAYER 4 IF

There is at least one meaningful outcome in your business that you no longer manage, only review, and you would be comfortable letting it run for a week while you were away.

THE CEILING

Usually organisational rather than technical. One or two processes reach Layer 4 while the rest of the business stays at 2 and 3, and the gap creates friction. Getting past it is less about building more systems and more about ownership, review, and trust.

5 Compounding

The systems become the operating model.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE DAY TO DAY

The core of the business runs on connected systems that hold the real record of what is happening. Intake, delivery, billing, follow up, and reporting are joined up rather than stitched together. People spend their time on judgment calls, relationships, and the work that genuinely needs a human, because the routine has been absorbed.

The distinguishing feature is not automation volume. It is that each system produces information that makes the next one better. Every job completed improves the estimate on the next quote. Every resolved exception narrows the category of things that need escalating. Improvement stops being a project and becomes a property of how you operate.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

- Taking on a large new client is a capacity question about people you need for judgment, not for processing.
- Your management reporting is a by-product of the work, not a task someone performs on a Friday.
- New staff become useful in days, because the system carries the process and they carry the thinking.
- You can answer "what is our margin on this type of job" from data rather than from instinct.

THE HONEST COSTS

Layer 5 is a real commitment. It requires someone accountable for the systems, a budget for maintaining them, and a willingness to change how people work rather than only what tools they use. Businesses that reach Layer 5 by buying software and not changing behaviour end up with an expensive, accurate record of a process nobody follows.

YOU ARE ON LAYER 5 IF

Growth conversations are about demand and strategy, not about whether operations can cope.

At Layer 5 the constraint moves from what your business can process to what your business decides to do.

03

Why almost everyone stalls at Layer 3

The most important section in this guide. If you read nothing else, read this. It explains the single structural reason businesses buy more automation and stop getting more value from it.

PART THREE · THE STALL

The problem is not your automations. It is that your business has no memory.

A typical business of twenty people runs on somewhere between eight and fifteen separate tools, and not one of them holds the whole truth about a customer.

Consider what happens to a single customer. The enquiry arrives by WhatsApp. Someone adds them to a spreadsheet. The quote is written in a document and emailed. The job is scheduled on a shared calendar. Delivery is tracked on a project board. The invoice is raised in accounting software. The complaint, three weeks later, arrives in a shared inbox and is answered by whoever saw it first.

Seven systems. Seven partial versions of one customer. The only place the complete picture has ever existed is in the heads of two or three people, and it exists there imperfectly.

Now ask why Layer 4 is impossible in that environment. A system that is supposed to own an outcome has to be able to answer questions like: has this person contacted us before, what did we quote them, was that job profitable, did we deliver late, are they still owed a credit. If no system can answer those questions, then no system can make a good decision. It can only follow a rule.

THE STALL, STATED PLAINLY

Automations fail to scale not because automation is limited, but because **a system cannot reason about information it cannot reach**. Every new automation you add to disconnected tools makes the tangle worse, because each one becomes another place where a partial version of the truth is created and maintained.

THE SYMPTOMS, IN CASE THEY SOUND FAMILIAR

- Someone spends hours each month building a report by copying between systems.
- Two people give a customer two different answers about the same job, and both are looking at a screen.
- You cannot say what a category of work costs you without a manual exercise.
- Every new tool you buy solves a problem and creates a new island.
- Your best operator's real skill is knowing where things actually are.

None of these are AI problems. They are all the same problem, and it has to be solved before intelligence is worth adding on top of it.

PART THREE · THE FOUNDATION

What "systems that talk to each other" actually means

Most business software has a door built into it for other software to come in through. Almost nobody uses those doors, which is why data gets moved by people instead.

The technical term is an interface, usually called an API. Strip the jargon away and it is simple: your accounting software, your calendar, your messaging platform, and your customer records each have a defined way for another program to ask them questions and give them instructions. Show me every unpaid invoice. Create this booking. Update this record. Tell me the moment this changes.

When those doors are connected properly, three things become true, and each one unlocks something you could not have before.

WHAT CHANGES	WHY IT MATTERS
One source of truth	A single place holds the authoritative record. Other tools reflect it rather than compete with it. Nobody has to decide which screen to believe.
Live, not copied	Information is read at the moment it is needed. Nothing is out of date, because nothing has been duplicated. Manual re-entry disappears as a category of work.
A place to act	A system can now not only read what is happening but do something about it, and record what it did. This is the precondition for delegating anything.

WHERE THE CUSTOM PART COMES IN

Connecting doors is only half of it. The other half is that your business has rules no off the shelf product knows. How you price a job. What makes a client high risk. What sequence of approvals a discount needs. Which supplier gets which category of work. That logic is the actual value of your business, and it currently lives in people's judgment.

Custom software is simply the place where that logic gets written down and made executable. That is the whole idea. Not a grand rebuild, not throwing out your tools, but a thin layer that sits across the tools you already pay for, holds the truth, and knows your rules.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

It is not replacing your accounting package. It is not a two year enterprise project. It is not asking your team to learn six new screens. In most cases the tools people use every day stay exactly where they are, and what changes is that they finally agree with each other.

PART THREE · THE DECISION

Off the shelf, configured, or custom

Custom is not automatically the right answer. It is the right answer in specific conditions, and expensive in all the others. Here is the honest comparison.

	OFF THE SHELF	CONFIGURED PLATFORM	CUSTOM SYSTEM
Best when	Your process is genuinely standard and you are happy to adopt someone else's way of working.	Your process is mostly standard with a few quirks that settings can absorb.	The way you work is the reason clients choose you, or no product covers your combination of needs.
Speed	Days.	Weeks.	Weeks to months, delivered in stages.
Real cost	Low licence fee, plus the hidden cost of the workarounds your team invents.	Moderate licence fee, plus configuration and a specialist to maintain it.	Higher upfront, low marginal cost as you grow. You own it.
Main risk	You bend your business to fit the software, and lose what made you different.	You outgrow the configuration limits and are stuck.	Poorly specified scope. The failure is almost always in definition, not code.
Ceiling	Layer 3.	Layer 3, occasionally 4 in one narrow area.	Layer 5.

THE PRACTICAL ANSWER FOR MOST BUSINESSES

A mix. Keep the off the shelf tools that do a commodity job well, because rebuilding accounting or email is a waste of money. Then build one custom layer that connects them, holds the authoritative record, and encodes the rules that are genuinely yours. That layer is small compared to a full platform, and it is the piece that makes Layer 4 possible.

THE QUESTION THAT SETTLES IT

Ask this about any process: **if we did this the standard way, would our clients notice, and would they mind?** If the answer is no, buy something. If the answer is yes, that process is part of your competitive position and it deserves to be built properly.

PART THREE · THE NUMBERS

What this actually costs and how long it takes

Vague answers to this question are how bad projects get sold. Here are honest ranges, what drives them, and how to keep control of the number.

SCOPE	TYPICAL TIME	WHAT YOU GET
Connector project	2 to 4 weeks	Two or three existing tools joined so data flows automatically, with one process running end to end. Usually the right first project.
Core system	6 to 12 weeks	A central record for customers or jobs, connected to your main tools, with your business rules encoded and a working interface for your team.
Operating platform	3 to 6 months, staged	Intake through delivery through billing joined up, with delegated systems handling defined outcomes and reporting produced automatically.

WHAT ACTUALLY DRIVES THE COST

- **How many tools have to be connected**, and whether they have proper interfaces. One badly documented legacy system can cost more than four modern ones.
- **The state of your data**. If customer records exist in four places with different spellings, cleaning that up is real work and it happens before anything else.
- **How clearly your rules are defined**. Undefined rules are discovered during the build, which is the most expensive time to discover them.
- **How many exceptions the process really has**. Everyone underestimates this. The first conversation always describes the happy path.

HOW TO KEEP CONTROL OF THE NUMBER

Insist on staged delivery with something usable at the end of each stage. A project that produces nothing you can touch for three months is a project that cannot be corrected. If a supplier cannot describe what you will be able to do at week four, that is a warning about the specification, not the technology.

Ranges vary with market, complexity, and how much of the definition work you do yourself. The single largest cost saving available to you is arriving with your processes already documented. That work is free and it is what Part Seven helps you do.

04

How these systems actually get built

So you can recognise a good process when you see one, and know what you are responsible for at each stage. Most failed projects fail in the first two stages, long before anything is built.

PART FOUR · THE BUILD

The seven stages

Notice how much of this happens before anyone writes code, and how much of it is your responsibility rather than your supplier's.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT YOU OWN
1 Discovery	Every process is mapped as it really runs, including the workarounds. Volumes, exceptions, and who touches what.	Honesty. Showing the messy version, not the version in the handbook.
2 Specification	What the system must do, what it must never do, what "correct" means, and what is explicitly out of scope.	Sign off. This document is the contract that protects you.
3 Data model	Deciding what a customer, a job, and a transaction are, which system is authoritative, and how records match up.	Settling disputes. Two departments will define "client" differently.
4 Foundation build	The central record and the connections to your existing tools. Unglamorous and the part everything else depends on.	Access. Accounts, permissions, and a named technical contact.
5 Workflow build	Your rules and interfaces. The part your team will actually see and use.	Availability of the people who do the work, not only management.
6 Review and refine	Real people run real work through it. Findings are fed back and the system is adjusted before it is trusted.	Time. This stage is skipped more often than any other and it is the one that determines adoption.
7 Launch and handover	Cutover, documentation, training, and an agreed way to raise issues and request changes.	Naming an owner before launch, not after.

THE STAGE NOBODY PROTECTS

Review and refine is where a system stops being technically complete and starts being trusted. Skipping it is how businesses end up with software that works perfectly and that nobody uses. If a timeline you are shown does not have this stage in it as protected time, ask where it went.

PART FOUR · THE BUILD

The five ways these projects fail

1. The happy path problem

Discovery captures how the process works when everything goes right, because that is how people describe their own jobs. The exceptions, which are where most of the labour actually is, surface halfway through the build and blow the scope. The fix is to ask, for every step, what happens when this goes wrong, and to insist on real examples from the last month.

2. Building for the org chart instead of the work

The system is designed around departments, so it recreates the handoffs and the silos in software. Design around the journey of a job or a customer, and let departments be a view of that, not the structure of it.

3. Nobody owns it

A system with no named owner degrades from the day it launches. Small errors are not corrected, the definition of correct drifts, and within a year people are keeping side spreadsheets again. Ownership is a role with time attached, not a line in an email.

4. Automating a broken process

If a process is bad, making it run faster and without supervision makes it worse at scale. Fix or simplify first, then build. A supplier who never suggests removing steps is not thinking about your business.

5. Treating launch as the end

The first version is a hypothesis. The value comes from the second and third, informed by what actually happened. Budget for iteration from the start, because the alternative is a system frozen at its least intelligent moment.

Almost every failure in this list is a definition failure, not a technology failure. That is good news, because definition is the part you control.

05

How they get operated after launch

Very little is written about this, which is why so many good systems quietly decay. What follows is what running these systems properly actually involves week to week.

PART FIVE · OPERATIONS

The operating rhythm

A system you do not review is a system you are slowly losing. The rhythm below is modest, roughly two hours a month for most businesses, and it is the difference between a system that improves and one that erodes.

CADENCE	WHAT YOU LOOK AT	WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY ASKING
Daily	The exception queue.	Is anything stuck waiting on a human, and has it been waiting too long? This should take minutes, and if it does not, that is itself the finding.
Weekly	Volume and escalation rate.	What proportion of cases needed a human, and is that proportion moving in the right direction?
Monthly	The escalations themselves, grouped.	Are the same three situations causing most of the escalations? If so, those are next month's improvements.
Quarterly	Scope and drift.	Has the business changed in ways the system has not? Are people working around it anywhere, and why?

THE ONE NUMBER WORTH TRACKING

Escalation rate: the percentage of cases the system could not complete on its own. It is the honest measure of how much you have actually delegated. A rate that is falling means the system is learning your business. A rate that is flat for months means nobody is feeding the findings back in.

A RATE OF ZERO IS A WARNING, NOT A WIN

If nothing ever escalates, the system is almost certainly making decisions it should not be making, and you will find out about it from a customer. Healthy delegated systems escalate a small, stable share of genuinely unusual cases.

PART FIVE · OPERATIONS

Ownership, escalation, and decay

The system owner

Every system needs one named person accountable for it. Not the supplier, not the IT contact, and not "the management team." This person does not need to be technical. They need to understand the process deeply enough to say whether a decision the system made was correct.

The role is roughly two to four hours a month and covers: watching the exception queue, collecting findings, deciding what gets improved next, and being the person the team tells when something looks wrong. Put it in a job description or it will not happen.

The escalation ladder

Good delegated systems have a defined ladder, and it is worth agreeing yours in writing before launch.

1. **Handle.** The case is within the defined outcome. The system completes it and logs what it did.
2. **Handle and flag.** Completed, but something was unusual. A human is told after the fact, not asked first.
3. **Pause and ask.** The system takes the safe action, holds, and asks a specific question of a specific person.
4. **Stop and escalate.** Outside scope entirely. Handed to a named human with the full context assembled.

The most common design mistake is having only levels one and four. Everything either happens silently or lands as a crisis. Levels two and three are where the trust is built.

How systems decay, and the early signs

- Someone starts keeping a side spreadsheet. Always the first symptom, always worth investigating rather than banning.
- The escalation queue grows a backlog nobody mentions.
- A new type of work is being handled entirely outside the system because "it does not fit."
- The original owner changed roles and nobody replaced them.
- Nobody can remember the last time it was changed.

Each of these is cheap to fix in the month it appears and expensive to fix a year later.

06

The four jumps

What actually changes at each jump, what has to be true before it is even possible, the trap that catches most people, and one thing you can do this week.

1→2 Asking to Assisting

From personal habit to shared standard.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGES

The change is not the tools. It is that your business starts keeping the good prompts. When one person works out how to get an excellent client update out of a messy set of notes, that method becomes something everyone uses rather than something one person knows.

WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE FIRST

- Someone is willing to own a shared library of prompts and standards. One person, not a committee.
- You have identified the three tasks that consume the most repetitive hours. Not the most annoying ones, the most frequent ones.
- People are allowed to say when the output was bad, without it being treated as resistance.

THE TRAP

Buying a subscription for everyone and calling it done. Adoption without a shared standard produces inconsistent quality, which is worse than no adoption, because now your client communication varies by who picked up the task.

DO THIS WEEK

Pick your single highest volume written task. Have your best person do it with AI three times, keep the prompt that worked, write down what good looks like, and give it to everyone else. That single document is your first piece of compounding value.

2→3 **Assisting to Automating**

From doing the steps to defining them.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGES

Work begins without a person starting it. To get there you have to be able to write down a process precisely enough that it can run without judgment, which is usually the first time anyone in the business has written it down at all.

WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE FIRST

- The process is stable. Automating something you are still redesigning wastes the work twice.
- It happens often enough to be worth it. A useful test: at least weekly, or high enough value that a single miss hurts.
- Someone has documented the exceptions honestly, including the ones people handle by instinct.
- You have agreed what happens when the automation fails, and who finds out.

THE TRAP

Automating the process you wish you had rather than the one you have. The other trap is the silent failure. Build the alert before you build the automation, or you will only discover breakages through complaints.

DO THIS WEEK

Take one process and write it out as numbered steps. Then, for every step, write what happens when it goes wrong. If you cannot fill in that second column from memory, you are not ready to automate it yet, and that is a useful thing to have learned in an hour rather than in a project.

3→4

Automating to Delegating

The jump most businesses never make. This is the one that matters.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGES

You stop specifying steps and start specifying outcomes. That sounds like a small shift in language and it is a complete change in what has to exist underneath. A system that owns an outcome needs to see the real state of the business, hold context across time, decide between options, and know the boundary of its own competence.

WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE FIRST

- **Your tools are connected.** This is the hard prerequisite and the reason most businesses stop here. Covered in Part Three.
- **There is one authoritative record** of a customer and a job, and everyone agrees which one it is.
- **The outcome is defined in writing**, including what must never happen under any circumstances.
- **A named person will own it** and has time allocated to review it.
- **You are willing to tolerate a settling period** where the system is right most of the time and you are checking it.

THE TRAP

Trying to buy this jump as a product. It is bought as a foundation and then a capability. Businesses that skip straight to the intelligent layer end up with a system making confident decisions on incomplete information, which is considerably worse than a person making cautious decisions on incomplete information.

DO THIS WEEK

List every tool that holds customer information. Next to each, write what it knows that no other tool knows. The length of that list is the size of your gap, and it is the single most useful page you can bring to any conversation about building.

4→5

Delegating to Compounding

From isolated wins to an operating model.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGES

The jump is mostly organisational. The technology at Layer 5 is not dramatically more advanced than at Layer 4. What changes is coverage and connection: enough of the business runs this way that the systems begin to feed each other, and improvement becomes continuous rather than occasional.

WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE FIRST

- Layer 4 has proven itself in at least one process for long enough that people trust it without checking.
- Systems share a common record, so what one learns is available to the others.
- Improvement has a budget and a rhythm, not just a project.
- Roles have genuinely changed. If people are still doing their old jobs plus supervising systems, you have added work rather than removed it.

THE TRAP

Scaling before trust is established. Rolling this across the business while people still quietly check every output produces the worst of both worlds: the cost of the systems and the cost of the labour. Prove one, let it earn trust, then expand.

DO THIS WEEK

Take your one working Layer 4 process and ask what information it produces that another part of the business would find valuable. That connection, made deliberately, is what compounding actually is.

07

Five prompts that produce real documents

Not tips. Each of these produces an artifact you can use in a meeting, hand to a supplier, or work from directly. Use them with any capable AI assistant. Together they take about two hours and they replace the most expensive part of a project.

PART SEVEN · WORKING PROMPTS

1. The process inventory

You get: a ranked list of every repeating process in your business, scored for automation potential. **Takes:** about 25 minutes.

PROMPT

You are helping me build a process inventory for my business. I will describe what we do and you will interview me until the inventory is complete.

My business: [what you do, how many people, roughly how many customers or jobs a month].

Ask me one question at a time. Work through our week from the first customer contact to the point we get paid. For every process you uncover, capture: what triggers it, who does it, how long it takes, how often it happens, which tools it touches, and what makes it go wrong.

Do not accept vague answers. If I say something is "usually" a certain way, ask what happens the rest of the time.

When we have covered everything, output a table of all processes ranked by total hours consumed per month, with a column scoring each one from 1 to 5 for how repeatable and rule based it is. Then tell me which three are the strongest candidates to change first, and why.

What to do with it: this is the document any competent supplier should ask for in a first meeting. Arriving with it already done removes weeks from a project and a meaningful amount from a quote.

2. The bottleneck audit

You get: a clear statement of where your capacity actually breaks, and whether it is a people, process, or data problem.

Takes: about 15 minutes.

PROMPT

Act as an operations analyst. I want to find the real constraint in my business, not the most annoying symptom.

Here is what we do and what our week looks like: [describe, and paste your process inventory if you have one].

Interview me to find where work waits. For each stage, ask what happens when volume doubles, who or what would break first, and what people do when that stage is overloaded.

Then tell me: what my true bottleneck is, whether it is a people problem, a process problem, or an information problem, and what evidence points to that conclusion. If the constraint is that information is scattered across tools, say so directly and explain which decisions are being made without complete information.

Finally, tell me what I would have to fix before automation would produce any real benefit.

What to do with it: this often changes the project people think they need. It is common to discover that the process everyone complains about is not the one costing the most.

PART SEVEN · WORKING PROMPTS

3. The data flow map

You get: a written map of where your information lives and every place a human moves it by hand. **Takes:** about 20 minutes.

PROMPT

Help me map how information moves through my business. The goal is to find every point where a person is acting as the connection between two systems.

Our tools: [list every tool, including spreadsheets, shared inboxes, and WhatsApp groups].

Walk me through the full life of one customer, from first contact to final payment and beyond. At each step ask: where does this information get entered, where does it get read from, and does anyone re-type or copy it from one place to another.

Then produce: a list of every system and what it holds, every point where information is manually transferred with an estimate of how often, and every place where the same fact is stored in more than one system. Finish by telling me which system is currently closest to being the authoritative record of a customer, and what it is missing to become that.

What to do with it: the manual transfer list is your automation shortlist. The duplicate storage list is your risk register. The last answer is your foundation project.

4. The knowledge extraction

You get: a written procedure for something that currently only exists in one person's head. **Takes:** 30 minutes with that person. **Do this before they go on leave, not after.**

PROMPT

I am going to describe a job I do regularly. Your task is to interview me until you could write a procedure detailed enough for a competent new person to follow without asking me anything.

The job: [name it].

Ask one question at a time. Pay particular attention to the decisions I make without thinking about them. When I mention judging, checking, or knowing something, stop and ask exactly what I am looking at and what would change my answer.

Keep asking about exceptions until I run out. Then output: the procedure as numbered steps, a separate list of decision rules in "if this, then that" form, a list of exceptions and how each is handled, and finally a list of the judgment calls that genuinely could not be written as a rule.

What to do with it: the decision rules are what a system would encode. The final list is the work that stays human, and knowing exactly what that is makes every later conversation more precise.

PART SEVEN · WORKING PROMPTS

5. The first draft specification

You get: a specification document you can hand to a supplier or use to sanity check one you have been given. **Takes:** about 30 minutes. Use the outputs of the first four prompts as input.

PROMPT

Help me write a first draft specification for a system that would take over one outcome in my business. Be rigorous and challenge me where my thinking is vague.

The outcome I want handed over: [describe it as a finished result, not as steps].

Here is my process documentation: [paste the outputs from the earlier prompts].

Interview me to fill the gaps, then produce a specification with these sections: the outcome defined precisely, what "done and correct" means, what the system must never do under any circumstances, the information it needs access to and from where, the decision rules it must follow, the four escalation levels and what triggers each, what gets logged, how success will be measured, and what is explicitly out of scope for the first version.

End with a list of the questions I could not answer well. Those are my open risks.

USE THAT FINAL LIST

The questions you could not answer are more valuable than the specification itself. They are the exact places where a project would have gone over budget, discovered mid build. Resolve them on paper, where it costs nothing.

A specification you wrote yourself also changes the conversation with any supplier. You are no longer being told what you need. You are asking whether they can deliver what you have defined, and how they would improve it.

PART EIGHT · YOUR SYSTEMS MAP

One page. Fill it in today.

Print it, fill it in by hand, and put it somewhere visible. Everything in this guide leads here.

WHERE YOUR INFORMATION LIVES

TOOL	WHAT IT KNOWS THAT NOTHING ELSE KNOWS	WHO MAINTAINS IT

WHERE A PERSON IS THE BRIDGE BETWEEN TWO SYSTEMS

FROM HERE, TO HERE	HOW OFTEN	WHO DOES IT

MY LAYER TODAY

HOURS PER MONTH LOST TO MANUAL TRANSFER

THE BLOCK I FAILED FIRST

THE ONE PROCESS TO FIX FIRST

WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE BEFORE WE CAN MAKE OUR NEXT JUMP

Send us your map.

If you have filled in the page before this one, you have done the work most businesses pay to have done for them. You know which layer you are on, where your information is stranded, and how many hours a month are being spent moving data between systems that should be talking to each other.

Send it to us and we will tell you exactly what is blocking your next jump. Not a sales call. A written response covering what we would fix first, roughly what it would take, and what you should not spend money on yet.

We do this because the businesses worth working with are the ones who have already thought about their own operations properly. If that is you, the conversation starts from a much better place.

layersyncai.com

LayerSync builds AI systems and custom software for businesses that have outgrown their tools. We connect what you already use, encode the rules that are genuinely yours, and hand over outcomes instead of steps.

The Layer Map · A LayerSync field guide · Share it freely.